Phase 3: Into the Promised Land

God's people cross the Jordan, see the walls of Jericho fall, cry out for rescuers again and again, and meet a loyal friend named Ruth who becomes part of Jesus' family.

At a Glance

Month	Month 3
Books covered	Joshua, Judges, Ruth (3 books)
Bible section(s)	History (books 1–3 of 12)
Big Idea	God keeps His promise and brings His people into the land. When they follow Him there is victory, when they wander there is trouble, and through it all God is working to bring a true King and Redeemer: Jesus.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God will be with you wherever you go." (Joshua 1:9, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"Be strong and courageous." (Joshua 1:9)
Theme color	Trumpet brass and harvest-wheat gold
Phase symbol / badge	🎺 The **Jericho Trumpet Badge**: a ram's horn trumpet over a tumbled wall, with a bundle of wheat for Ruth
Running total of books learned	8 of 66 (Law 5 of 5 ✔ · History 3 of 12)

The Big Idea (in kid words)

After 40 years in the wilderness, God's people finally walk into the **Promised Land**! God tells their new leader, **Joshua**, "Be strong and courageous. I am with you." God stops a river and knocks down the walls of **Jericho**. But after Joshua dies, the people forget God again and again. Each time they get into trouble, they cry out, and God sends a rescuer called a **judge**. In the middle of those messy days, a young widow named **Ruth** shows loyal love, and God gives her a family. Her great-grandson is **King David**!

How this points to Jesus: The name **Joshua** means "**the LORD saves**," and it's the same name as **Jesus** in Hebrew (*Yeshua*). Joshua led God's people into the Promised Land; Jesus leads us into God's forever home. **Rahab** was saved by trusting God and hanging a **scarlet (red) cord** in her window, and she became part of Jesus' family tree (Matthew 1:5)! The judges were rescuers who weren't perfect and couldn't fix people's hearts, so the people needed a perfect Savior and King. **Boaz** was Ruth's "guardian-redeemer," a relative who paid the price to rescue her family. Jesus is our **Redeemer** who paid for us with His life. Ruth's baby was born in **Bethlehem's** family line, the same town where Jesus would be born.

The Books in Easy Words

Review: The 5 Books of the Law 📜

Genesis (beginnings 🌅), Exodus (rescue 🚪), Leviticus (holy 🙏), Numbers (wilderness 🔢), Deuteronomy (remember ❤️). **Section complete!**

Book 6: Joshua

How to say it	JOSH-oo-uh
How to spell it	Josh-u-a: **J-O-S-H-U-A** (3 claps)
Section	History (book 1 of 12)
Traditional author	Joshua (with a few later additions, such as the account of his death)
Chapters	24
One-sentence kid summary	God helped Joshua lead His people across the Jordan River into the Promised Land, knocked down Jericho's walls, and kept every promise He made.
In one word	**CONQUER** (or **PROMISE-KEEPER**)
Key people	Joshua, Rahab, the two spies, Caleb, Achan, the Gibeonites, the priests carrying the ark
Key stories	"Be strong and courageous" (1); Rahab hides the spies and hangs a scarlet cord (2); the Jordan River stops so the people cross on dry ground, and 12 memorial stones (3–4); the commander of the LORD's army (5:13–15); the walls of Jericho fall (6); Achan's hidden sin and the battle of Ai (7–8); the Gibeonites' trick (9); the sun stands still (10); Caleb, 85 years old, asks for his mountain (14); the land is divided among the tribes (13–21); "Not one of all the LORD's good promises... failed" (21:45); "As for me and my household, we will serve the LORD" (24:15)
Where Jesus shows up	Joshua's name = Jesus' name ("the LORD saves"); Rahab in Jesus' family line (Matthew 1:5) and a hero of faith (Hebrews 11:31); the scarlet cord as a sign of rescue, like the Passover blood; the "rest" in the land points to the greater rest Jesus gives (Hebrews 4:8–10)
Hand motion / picture	🎺 **March and blow:** march in place while holding your fists to your mouth like a trumpet: "Toot-toot! Walls fall down!"

Book 7: Judges

How to say it	JUJ-iz
How to spell it	Judg-es: **J-U-D-G-E-S** (2 claps). *Tip: "judge" + "s." Don't forget the silent D before the G!*
Section	History (book 2 of 12)
Traditional author	Samuel (according to Jewish tradition)
Chapters	21

One-sentence kid summary	After Joshua died, God's people kept forgetting God and getting into trouble, so God sent 12 rescuers called judges to save them again and again.
In one word	**CYCLE** (sin → suffer → shout → Savior → silence, then again)
Key people	The 12 judges: Othniel, Ehud (a left-handed hero), Shamgar, **Deborah** (with Barak), **Gideon**, Tola, Jair, Jephthah, Ibzan, Elon, Abdon, **Samson**; also Jael, Delilah, and enemy kings and armies (Canaanites, Midianites, Philistines)
Key stories	The cycle begins (2:10–19); Ehud defeats a cruel king (3); Deborah the judge and prophet leads Barak to victory (4–5); Gideon, the "mighty warrior" hiding in a winepress, the fleece, and the 300 men with trumpets, jars and torches (6–7); Samson, the strongman with a Nazirite vow, the lion, Delilah, and the temple pillars (13–16); "In those days Israel had no king; everyone did as they saw fit" (21:25)
Where Jesus shows up	Every judge was a flawed savior, showing we need a *perfect* Savior; the book ends longing for a good King, and Jesus is that King; Samson's greatest victory came when he gave up his life, a faint picture of Jesus defeating the enemy through His death; God's Spirit coming on the judges points to the Holy Spirit Jesus gives
Hand motion / picture	🔨 **Gavel:** pound one fist gently on your other palm like a judge's hammer, then draw a circle in the air (the cycle).

Book 8: Ruth

How to say it	ROOTH
How to spell it	Ruth: **R-U-T-H** (1 clap)
Section	History (book 3 of 12)
Traditional author	Unknown (Jewish tradition says Samuel)
Chapters	4
One-sentence kid summary	Ruth stayed loyal to her mother-in-law Naomi and to God, and kind Boaz became her family's redeemer, and their great-grandson was King David.
In one word	**LOYALTY** (the Hebrew word *hesed*: loyal, faithful, never-giving-up love)
Key people	Naomi, Elimelech, Mahlon and Kilion (Naomi's sons), Orpah, Ruth (from the nation of Moab), Boaz, Obed (Ruth's baby)
Key stories	A famine; Naomi's family moves to Moab and her husband and sons die (1); "Where you go I will go… your God my God" (1:16); Naomi returns to Bethlehem bitter ("Call me Mara," 1:20); Ruth gleans (gathers leftover grain) in Boaz's field, and Boaz is kind to her (2); Ruth asks Boaz to be her family's guardian-redeemer (3); Boaz redeems the family land and marries Ruth, sealed with a sandal at the city gate (4); baby Obed is born, the grandfather of David (4:17)
Where Jesus shows up	Boaz the guardian-redeemer points to Jesus our Redeemer (Galatians 4:4–5; 1 Peter 1:18–19); Ruth, a foreigner, welcomed into God's family shows the gospel is for all nations; Ruth is in Jesus' family tree (Matthew 1:5); the story happens in **Bethlehem**, Jesus' birthplace

Hand motion / picture	🌾 **Gather and hug:** scoop up pretend grain from the ground with both hands, then hug yourself ("loyal love!").

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher (plain adult language)

Where we are in the story. At the end of Deuteronomy, Moses has died and Israel is camped east of the Jordan River, across from Jericho. These three books cover about 300–350 years in the land, from the conquest (traditionally around 1400 BC) to just before the time of Samuel and the kings.

- **Joshua** shows God's faithfulness to His promise to Abraham (Genesis 15:18–21). Key themes: courage that comes from God's presence (1:5–9), the importance of complete obedience (Achan, ch. 7), God fighting for Israel (Jericho, ch. 6; Gibeon, ch. 10), and covenant renewal (ch. 24). The conquest was a divine judgment on Canaanite nations for centuries of evil, including child sacrifice (see Genesis 15:16; Deuteronomy 9:4–5; 12:31), and God had waited over 400 years. Note also that individuals who turned to God, such as Rahab and the Gibeonites, were spared.
- **Judges** is a downward spiral. The "cycle" repeats seven times: Israel **sins** (worships idols), God lets them **suffer** under enemies, they **shout** (cry out) to God, God sends a **savior** (a judge), and there is **silence** (peace) until the judge dies. Each time it gets worse, and even the judges get worse (Gideon begins well and ends making an idol, 8:27; Samson is impulsive and self-centered). The refrain, "In those days Israel had no king; everyone did as they saw fit" (17:6; 21:25), prepares for the coming of kings in Samuel, and ultimately points to the need for Jesus. Judges 17–21 are very dark chapters; we do not teach them to children.
- **Ruth** is set "in the days when the judges ruled" (1:1), but it's a bright, beautiful contrast: ordinary people showing **hesed** (loyal covenant love) in everyday life. Ruth is a Moabite (a nation usually at odds with Israel), yet she chooses Israel's God. Boaz acts as a **guardian-redeemer** (Hebrew *go'el*), a close relative who had the right and duty to buy back family land and care for a widow's family (Leviticus 25:25; Deuteronomy 25:5–6). The book ends with a genealogy leading to **David**, showing that God was quietly preparing a king, and ultimately the Messiah.

Key truths to emphasize

1. **God keeps every promise.** (Joshua 21:45; 23:14)
2. **God's presence gives courage.** (Joshua 1:9)
3. **Obedience matters; hidden sin hurts everyone.** (Joshua 7)
4. **Choose today whom you will serve.** (Joshua 24:15)
5. **When we forget God, life goes in circles of trouble, but God hears when we cry out.** (Judges 2:18)
6. **God uses unlikely people** (a left-handed man, a woman judge, a fearful farmer, a foreign widow).
7. **We need a perfect Savior and King: Jesus.** (Judges 21:25)
8. **God works through ordinary kindness and loyalty.** (Ruth 2:12; 3:10)

Timeline and map notes

- **Timeline:** Moses dies → Joshua crosses the Jordan (traditionally around 1406 BC) → conquest (about 7 years; see Caleb's age in Joshua 14:7–10) → land divided → Joshua dies at 110 → the judges (about 300 years) → Ruth (during the judges, about three generations before David) → Samuel (next month!).
- **Map:** Draw the Jordan River (from the Sea of Galilee down to the Dead Sea). Mark **Jericho** (just west of the Jordan), **Ai**, **Gibeon**, **Shiloh** (where the tabernacle stood), **Hebron** (Caleb's land), **Bethlehem** (Ruth and Boaz) and **Moab** (east of the Dead Sea). Show the 12 tribal areas with colored paper. Older kids: note the Philistines on the coast (Samson's enemies, and Goliath's people later).

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers / Ambassadors (11–17)
Battles and the conquest (Jericho, Ai)	Focus on the miracle: "God made the walls fall down!" Skip what happened to the people inside, except "Rahab's family was safe!"	Honest but brief: there were battles, and God was judging nations that had done very evil things for a long time. Highlight Rahab's rescue.	Discuss the hard question openly (see Big Question 1). Read Genesis 15:16, Deuteronomy 9:4–5 and Joshua 5:13–14 ("Neither… I am commander of the army of the LORD").
Rahab's background	"Rahab didn't know God yet, but she chose to trust Him."	"Rahab had been living a sinful life, but God forgave and saved her."	You may say she was a prostitute (Joshua 2:1; Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25); emphasize grace: God welcomes anyone who turns to Him.
Achan (Joshua 7:24–26)	Skip the punishment: "Achan hid things God said not to take, and it hurt everyone."	"Achan's sin had very serious consequences."	Discuss the seriousness of sin within God's covenant community, and contrast it with grace in Christ.
Ehud and Eglon, Jael and Sisera (Judges 3–4)	Skip.	Say only: "God used Ehud and Jael to defeat cruel enemy leaders."	You may read the passages; discuss why the Bible records violence honestly without approving everything.
Jephthah's vow (Judges 11)	Skip.	Skip.	Optional for Ambassadors: a tragic example of a foolish vow and of how far Israel had drifted (God forbids child sacrifice, Deuteronomy 12:31).

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers / Ambassadors (11–17)
Samson and Delilah	"Samson was very strong because God gave him strength. He made bad choices, but at the end he prayed and God helped him one last time."	Describe his poor choices (wanting his own way). Skip romance details.	Discuss how a gifted person can waste gifts, and God's grace even at the end (Hebrews 11:32).
Judges 19–21	Skip.	Skip.	Skip in class. If asked, acknowledge "the end of Judges shows how terrible things become when everyone does what they want," and talk privately or with parents.
Ruth at the threshing floor (Ruth 3)	"Ruth asked Boaz to take care of her family."	Same; explain it was a respectful custom for asking a guardian-redeemer for help.	Explain the customs (spreading the corner of a garment = a request for protection and marriage, compare Ezekiel 16:8); Boaz acts with integrity (3:11–14).
Death and grief (Naomi's husband and sons die)	"Naomi was very sad because her family died. But God took care of her."	Discuss grief honestly; it's okay to be sad and to tell God.	Talk about Naomi's honest lament (1:20–21) and how God was working when she couldn't see it.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"How did the walls of Jericho fall down?"** God did it! The people obeyed by marching and shouting, but God's power knocked down the walls (Hebrews 11:30: "By faith the walls of Jericho fell").
- **"Did the sun really stand still?"** The Bible says God answered Joshua's prayer and made the day longer (Joshua 10:12–14). We don't know exactly *how*, but God made the sun and can do anything with it.
- **"Why did God let His people be beaten by enemies in Judges?"** Like a loving parent, God let them feel the hurt of their choices so they'd turn back to Him. And every time they cried out, He rescued them.
- **"Was Samson's strength in his hair?"** His strength came from God. His long hair was a sign of his special promise (a Nazirite vow) to belong to God. When he broke that promise completely, God's strength left him (Judges 16:17–20).
- **"Why did Gideon only get 300 men?"** So everyone would know that *God* won the battle, not the army (Judges 7:2).
- **"Can girls be leaders like Deborah?"** Deborah was a prophet and judge whom God used to lead Israel (Judges 4:4). God used her courage and faith in a powerful way. *(Teacher: different churches apply this to church leadership in different ways. Keep the focus on God using Deborah's faith and courage.)*

- **"What's a redeemer?"** Someone who pays a price to buy something or someone back. Boaz bought back Naomi's family land and took care of Ruth. Jesus paid for us with His life to bring us back to God.
- **"Why is Ruth's story in the Bible if it's not about battles?"** Because God cares about ordinary people and everyday kindness, and because Ruth's family leads to King David and to Jesus!

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson title	Key point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Joshua 1–6	**Be Strong and Courageous**	God is with us wherever we go, so we can be brave, and God can knock down any wall.	SharefaithKids "Jericho"; BibleJourneyTV "Joshua"; BibleProject "Overview: Joshua"	Jericho Walls; Crossing the Jordan	Jericho Trumpet; Rahab's Scarlet Cord Window
2	Joshua 7; 14:6–15; 21:43–45; 24:14–28	**Choose Whom You Will Serve**	God keeps every promise, so we choose to follow Him fully.	SharefaithKids "Joshua"; BibleJourneyTV "Joshua"; BibleProject "Overview: Joshua" (second half) / "The Covenants"	Rahab's Rescue Rope; Twelve Stones Stepping Race	Memorial Stones; "As for Me and My House" Door Hanger
3	Judges 2:10–19; 4–7; 13–16 (selected)	**Rescuers in Messy Times**	When we forget God, we go in circles of trouble, but God hears and rescues, and Jesus is the perfect Rescuer.	SharefaithKids "Gideon" / "Samson"; BibleJourneyTV "Gideon"; BibleProject "Overview: Judges"	Gideon's Shrinking Army; Torch & Trumpet Night Tag	Gideon's Jar & Torch; Judges Cycle Wheel
4	Ruth 1–4	**Loyal Love and a Redeemer**	God shows loyal love through ordinary people, and Jesus is our Redeemer.	SharefaithKids "Ruth"; BibleJourneyTV "Ruth"; BibleProject "Overview: Ruth"	Ruth's Gleaning Grab	Wheat Sheaf Craft; Ruth-to-Jesus Family Tree
5 (optional)	Review Genesis–Ruth	**Review & Fun Sunday**	I know 8 books: the Law and the start of History!	Class favorite	Promised Land Game Show; History Shelf Hop	Passport stamping + badge ceremony

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📅 2nd & 4th Sunday Plan

Our class meets on the **2nd and 4th Sundays** of each month, so the four lessons below are taught **two at a time**. Each Sunday is still 75 minutes, with two shorter stories. Use the full lesson write-ups in **Weekly Lessons** for scripts, questions and supplies.

Sunday	2027 date*	Teach	Big takeaway
2nd Sunday	Mar 14	**Lesson 1: "Be Strong and Courageous"** (Joshua 1–6) + **Lesson 2: "Choose Whom You Will Serve"** (Joshua 7; 14:6–15; 21:43–45; 24:14–28)	God is with us wherever we go, so we can be brave, and God can knock down any wall. God keeps every promise, so we choose to follow Him fully.
4th Sunday	Mar 28	**Lesson 3: "Rescuers in Messy Times"** (Judges 2:10–19; 4–7; 13–16 (selected)) + **Lesson 4: "Loyal Love and a Redeemer"** (Ruth 1–4) + **End-of-Phase Review**	When we forget God, we go in circles of trouble, but God hears and rescues, and Jesus is the perfect Rescuer. God shows loyal love through ordinary people, and Jesus is our Redeemer.

**Dates assume a January 2027 start. See the Program Overview for the full calendar.*

> ⚠️ **Mar 28, 2027 is Easter Sunday.** If your class has an Easter lesson that day (Phase 9's "He Is Alive!" lesson fits well), send Lessons 3 & 4 (Judges and Ruth) home as a family reading week and hold the Phase 3 check-offs on Apr 11.

2nd Sunday: "Be Strong and Courageous" + "Choose Whom You Will Serve"

Time	Segment	What to do
0:00–0:08	🎵 Welcome & Book Chant	Attendance, then sing this phase's book song with motions.
0:08–0:20	📖 Story 1	**Be Strong and Courageous** (Joshua 1–6). Use the Lesson 1 hook and story script. Key point: *God is with us wherever we go, so we can be brave, and God can knock down any wall.*
0:20–0:28	📺 Video	Show **one** video (Little Lambs & Explorers: Sharefaith Kids; Trailblazers & Ambassadors: BibleProject). Options: SharefaithKids "Jericho"; BibleJourneyTV "Joshua"; BibleProject "Overview: Joshua". Send the others home on the family page.
0:28–0:40	📖 Story 2	**Choose Whom You Will Serve** (Joshua 7; 14:6–15; 21:43–45; 24:14–28). Use the Lesson 2 script. Key point: *God keeps every promise, so we choose to follow Him fully.*
0:40–0:48	💬 Small Groups	Ask 1 question from Lesson 1 and 1 from Lesson 2 for your age group, then: "Where did we see Jesus today?"
0:48–0:58	🎮 Game	**Jericho Walls** (Lesson 1). Backup: Rahab's Rescue Rope.

Time	Segment	What to do
0:58–1:10	🖍️ Activity	**Memorial Stones** (Lesson 2). Early finishers: this phase's coloring page or word search.
1:10–1:15	✅ Memory, Spelling & Prayer	Say the memory verse, spell 1–2 new books together, give stars, and pray. Send home the Take-Home Family Page.

4th Sunday: "Rescuers in Messy Times" + "Loyal Love and a Redeemer"

Time	Segment	What to do
0:00–0:08	🎵 Welcome & Book Chant	Attendance, then sing this phase's book song with motions. Then a 2-minute recap: "What do you remember from last time?"
0:08–0:20	📖 Story 1	**Rescuers in Messy Times** (Judges 2:10–19; 4–7; 13–16 (selected)). Use the Lesson 3 hook and story script. Key point: *When we forget God, we go in circles of trouble, but God hears and rescues, and Jesus is the perfect Rescuer.*
0:20–0:28	📺 Video	Show **one** video (Little Lambs & Explorers: Sharefaith Kids; Trailblazers & Ambassadors: BibleProject). Options: SharefaithKids "Gideon" / "Samson"; BibleJourneyTV "Gideon"; BibleProject "Overview: Judges". Send the others home on the family page.
0:28–0:40	📖 Story 2	**Loyal Love and a Redeemer** (Ruth 1–4). Use the Lesson 4 script. Key point: *God shows loyal love through ordinary people, and Jesus is our Redeemer.*
0:40–0:48	💬 Small Groups	Ask 1 question from Lesson 3 and 1 from Lesson 4 for your age group, then: "Where did we see Jesus today?"
0:48–0:56	🎮 Game	**Gideon's Shrinking Army** (Lesson 3). Backup: Ruth's Gleaning Grab.
0:56–1:04	🖍️ Activity	**Wheat Sheaf Craft** (Lesson 4). Early finishers: this phase's coloring page or word search.
1:04–1:15	✅ Review, Passport & Prayer	Run the **End-of-Phase** oral check-offs by age group, stamp Bible Passports, hand out the phase badge, and pray. Anyone not finished can check off on the next 2nd Sunday.

🏠 Between Sundays (the 1st and 3rd weeks)

Kids go two weeks between classes, so the home weeks keep the memory work going. Put these on the family page or text them to parents:

- **After the 2nd Sunday:** Sing the book song once a day, practice this phase's spelling words (5 minutes), read or listen to Joshua 1–6 and Joshua 7; 14:6–15; 21:43–45; 24:14–28 with a picture Bible, and watch the video the class didn't see.
- **After the 4th Sunday:** Read Ruth 1–4 together, talk through the 3 dinner-table questions, and keep singing the whole song so far. The next phase starts on the 2nd Sunday!
- **Teachers:** A quick text or photo to parents mid-week ("This week, practice spelling ___!") makes a big difference.

✂️ What to Trim When Time Is Short

Two lessons in one Sunday means you **won't use everything** in the Weekly Lessons. Keep these, in this order: (1) both story scripts, (2) the memory verse and book song, (3) one game, (4) one activity. Extra games, crafts, trivia and puzzles become take-home pages, early-finisher options or fun for a 5th-Sunday or special event.

> 💡 **Optional bonus:** "Review & Fun Sunday" (the old Week 5 review) can be used for a special event, a 5th Sunday if your church holds class, or folded into the 4th Sunday's review time.

Weekly Lessons

> 📅 **Twice a month:** The four lessons below are taught in pairs: **Lessons 1 & 2 on the 2nd Sunday**, **Lessons 3 & 4 on the 4th Sunday**. See the 2nd & 4th Sunday Plan above for the 75-minute run sheets. "Week 1–4" below means Lesson 1–4.

Week 1: Be Strong and Courageous 🎺

Scripture: Joshua 1:1–9; 2:1–21; 3:1–4:9; 6:1–25

Lesson goal: Kids will know that God told Joshua to be strong and courageous because God was with him, that Rahab trusted God and was saved, that God stopped the Jordan River, and that God made the walls of Jericho fall.

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Wall"

- *Supplies:* 15–20 empty cardboard boxes or plastic cups, stacked into a "wall"; a toy trumpet or a kazoo.
- *Do:* Build the wall before class. "Imagine you had to get into a city with walls this tall and thick, as tall as a house! Could you push it down by yourself?" Let a volunteer try to "think" it down. "No? What if I told you that God told His people to just walk around it and shout?" Blow the kazoo and have everyone shout; secretly have a helper knock it down. "When God is with us, nothing is too big for Him!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Moses had died, and God's people were waiting by the **Jordan River**. On the other side was the land God had promised to Abraham hundreds of years before! God chose **Joshua** to be the new leader. Joshua might have felt a little scared. Moses was a hard act to follow!
>
> But God told Joshua, "**Be strong and courageous! Do not be afraid. Do not be discouraged. For the LORD your God will be with you wherever you go.**"

> Joshua sent two spies to look at the big city of **Jericho**. A woman named **Rahab** lived in a house built into the city wall. She hadn't followed God before, but she had heard how God opened the Red Sea. She said, "I know the LORD has given you this land. Your God is God in heaven above and on the earth below!" She hid the spies on her roof under stalks of flax. Then she let them down by a rope out her window. The spies told her, "Tie this **scarlet (red) cord** in your window, and everyone in your house will be safe."
>
> Next, God's people had to cross the Jordan River, and it was flooding! God said, "Have the priests carry the ark of the covenant into the water." As soon as their feet touched the river, the water stopped flowing and piled up far upstream! All the people crossed on **dry ground**, just like at the Red Sea! Joshua had 12 men take 12 stones from the riverbed to make a pile, so that when children asked, "What do these stones mean?" their parents could say, "God stopped the river for us!"
>
> Then came Jericho. Its gates were shut tight. God gave Joshua a very strange plan: "March around the city once a day for six days. Have seven priests blow trumpets made of rams' horns. On the seventh day, march around **seven times**. When you hear a long trumpet blast, everyone **SHOUT**!"
>
> So they did. Day 1, around once. Day 2, around once. All the way to Day 6. On Day 7, they marched around... 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7 times! The trumpets blew, the people gave a great shout, and **the walls came tumbling down!**
>
> And Rahab? Her family was safe because of the red cord in the window. She came to live with God's people, and many years later, she became the great-great-...-grandmother of **Jesus**!
>
> Joshua's name means "the LORD saves." Jesus has the very same name! Jesus is with us wherever we go, so we can be strong and courageous too.

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** March around the room 7 times while counting, then shout and "fall down" like the walls. Repeat often: "Be strong and courageous! God is with me!" with a flexed-arm "strong" motion.
- **Explorers:** Act out the spies and Rahab (a red ribbon in a "window"). Count the marches together. Have them find Joshua 1:9 with the Contents page.
- **Trailblazers:** Compare the Jordan crossing to the Red Sea (Joshua 4:23). Talk about Rahab's faith (Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25). Look at the commander of the LORD's army (5:13–15): God isn't on "our side"; we must be on His.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss what courage looks like for a Christian teen today. Talk about memorials: what "12 stones" could help them remember what God has done in their lives?

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who was the new leader after Moses? (Joshua) (2) What color was Rahab's cord? (Red!) (3) What happened when the people shouted? (The walls fell down!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did God promise Joshua? (2) Why did Rahab help the spies? (3) Why do you think God gave such a strange plan for Jericho?

- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why did God tell Joshua *three times* to be strong and courageous (1:6, 7, 9)? (2) What do the 12 stones teach about remembering God's faithfulness? (3) What does Rahab's story teach about who God welcomes?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Where does real courage come from, according to Joshua 1:9? (2) The commander said he wasn't for Israel or its enemies (5:13–14). What does that mean for how we see "our side" today? (3) Rahab was saved by faith before she'd done anything "good." How does that connect to the gospel?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Jericho" or "Joshua" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jericho` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Joshua" or "Jericho" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Joshua` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Joshua" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Joshua` |

Teacher: preview every video first. Some Joshua videos include battle scenes; choose what fits your group. Follow-up questions: (1) How did God show He was with Joshua? (2) What do you need courage for this week?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Jericho Walls* and *Crossing the Jordan*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Jericho Trumpet* and *Rahab's Scarlet Cord Window*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Joshua 1:9 (Little Lambs: "Be strong and courageous."). Spell **J-O-S-H-U-A**. Trailblazers: **J-E-R-I-C-H-O**, **C-O-U-R-A-G-E-O-U-S**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You that You are with us wherever we go. When we feel scared, help us be strong and courageous. Thank You for Jesus, whose name means "the LORD saves." Amen.

Week 2: Choose Whom You Will Serve 🪨🏠

Scripture: Joshua 7:1–26 (summarized); 14:6–15; 21:43–45; 24:14–28

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that hidden sin hurts everyone (Achan), that faithful Caleb kept trusting God into old age, that God kept every promise, and that Joshua challenged everyone to choose to serve the LORD.

Opening hook / object lesson: "One Rotten Apple"

- *Supplies:* A bowl of fresh apples (or pictures) and one bruised or rotten apple hidden underneath; two signs: "God's way" and "My way."
- *Do:* Lift out the good apples, then reveal the rotten one at the bottom. "What happens if you leave one rotten apple in the bowl? It can spoil the others! In Joshua, one man hid something he

shouldn't have, and it hurt everyone." Then hold up the two signs. "Every day, we choose: God's way or my way. Joshua made his choice. Let's find out what it was!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> After Jericho, God had given one rule: "Don't take any of the treasure for yourselves. It belongs to the LORD." But a man named **Achan** saw a beautiful robe, some silver and a bar of gold. He thought, "Nobody will know." He took them and **hid** them under his tent.
>
> Next, Israel went to fight a little town called **Ai**, and they lost! Joshua fell on his face before God. "Why, LORD?" God said, "Someone has disobeyed and hidden what they took." Achan finally confessed, "It's true. I saw, I wanted, I took, I hid." Achan's sin was very serious, and it hurt the whole nation. After it was dealt with, God gave Israel victory. Sin we hide never stays hidden from God.
>
> Years went by, and God's people took more and more of the land. One day an old man came to Joshua. It was **Caleb**, one of the two brave spies from 45 years before! Caleb said, "I'm **85 years old**, but I'm still as strong as I was the day Moses sent me! Give me that hill country God promised me. The LORD will help me!" And Joshua gave Caleb the city of **Hebron**. Caleb trusted God his whole life long.
>
> Then the land was divided among the **12 tribes** of Israel, like a big family sharing a giant gift. The Bible says, "**Not one of all the LORD's good promises to Israel failed; every one was fulfilled.**" Remember God's promise to Abraham? A land, a big family, a blessing. God kept it!
>
> When Joshua was very old, he gathered all the people. He reminded them of everything God had done, from Abraham to Egypt to the Red Sea to Jericho. Then he said, "Now choose for yourselves this day whom you will serve. You can follow the false gods, or the LORD. **But as for me and my household, we will serve the LORD.**"
>
> The people shouted, "We will serve the LORD!" Joshua set up a big stone under a tree as a reminder of their promise. Then Joshua died at 110 years old.
>
> Every day, we choose too. Jesus said, "Follow me." When we choose Jesus, He forgives our hidden sins when we confess them, and He helps us follow Him all our lives, like Caleb did.

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Use the two signs: kids point to "God's way" or "My way" as you describe kid choices (sharing, hitting, obeying, telling the truth). Repeat: "I will serve the LORD!"
- **Explorers:** Discuss Achan's four steps: "I saw, I wanted, I took, I hid" (7:21). Compare them with Eve in Genesis 3:6. Talk about how to stop sin at step 1 or 2. Celebrate Caleb's lifelong faith.
- **Trailblazers:** Read Joshua 21:43–45 and list the promises God kept. Discuss what "serving the LORD" looks like at home ("me and my household").
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss hidden sin and confession (1 John 1:9; Proverbs 28:13). Discuss Joshua 24:15 as a personal decision: faith can't be inherited from parents; each person must choose.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What did Achan do with the things he took? (Hid them) (2) How old was Caleb? (85, still strong!) (3) What did Joshua say his family would do? ("Serve the LORD!")
- *Explorers:* (1) Why was it wrong for Achan to take the treasure? (2) What made Caleb so brave, even when he was old? (3) What's one way your family can serve the LORD?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why does hidden sin affect other people? (2) What do the words "not one promise failed" tell you about God? (3) Why did Joshua make the people *choose* instead of just telling them what to do?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) What is the difference between hiding sin and confessing it? What happens with each? (2) Caleb "followed the LORD wholeheartedly" (14:8, 14). What would wholehearted faith look like for you? (3) Is it possible to grow up in a Christian family and still need to make your own choice? Explain.

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Joshua" or "Achan" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Joshua` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Joshua" or "Caleb" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Caleb` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Joshua" (focus on the second half) or theme video "The Covenants" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Covenants` |

Preview first. Follow-up questions: (1) What promises did God keep in the book of Joshua? (2) What choice did Joshua ask the people to make?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Rahab's Rescue Rope* and *Twelve Stones Stepping Race*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Memorial Stones* and *"As for Me and My House" Door Hanger*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Joshua 1:9 (whole verse for Explorers+). Bonus for older groups: Joshua 24:15b. Spell **C-A-L-E-B**, **R-A-H-A-B**; Trailblazers: **P-R-O-M-I-S-E**, **S-E-R-V-E**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Faithful God, You have never broken one promise. Help us confess our sins instead of hiding them, and help us choose every day: "We will serve the LORD!" Amen.

Week 3: Rescuers in Messy Times 🔥🦁

Scripture: Judges 2:10–19 (the cycle); 4:1–16 (Deborah); 6:11–16, 36–40; 7:1–22 (Gideon); 13:1–5, 24–25; 16:4–30 (Samson, selected); 21:25

Lesson goal: Kids will learn the Judges "cycle" (sin, suffer, shout, Savior, silence), meet Deborah, Gideon and Samson, and understand that people needed a perfect Savior and King, Jesus.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Round and Round"

- *Supplies:* A toy car or ball and a circular track (or tape a circle on the floor); five signs around the circle: SIN, SUFFER, SHOUT, SAVIOR, SILENCE (peace).
- *Do:* Walk (or roll the car) around the circle, stopping at each sign. "God's people forgot Him (SIN). Enemies were mean to them (SUFFER). They cried to God (SHOUT). God sent a rescuer (SAVIOR). There was peace for a while (SILENCE)... and then they forgot God AGAIN!" Keep going around faster. "Round and round and round! That's the book of Judges. They needed someone to break the circle!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> After Joshua died, a new generation grew up who didn't know the LORD or what He had done. They started worshiping fake gods called idols. So God let enemy nations come and bully them. Then the people cried out, "Help us, LORD!" And God, who is so kind, sent a rescuer called a **judge**. A judge was a leader God used to save His people. Then there was peace... until the people forgot God again. This happened over and over, like going in circles!
>
> One judge was a woman named **Deborah**. She was a prophet who sat under a palm tree, and people came to her for help. A cruel enemy general named **Sisera** had 900 iron chariots! Deborah told a man named **Barak**, "God says go fight, and He will win the battle for you." Barak said, "I'll only go if you go with me." So Deborah went! The LORD threw Sisera's army into a panic, the Kishon River swept the enemy away (Judges 4:15; 5:21), and Sisera's army ran. Afterward, Deborah sang a song of praise to God.
>
> Later, God's people were being robbed by the **Midianites**. A young man named **Gideon** was hiding in a winepress, secretly threshing wheat. An angel of the LORD appeared and said, "**The LORD is with you, mighty warrior!**" Gideon looked around: "Who, me?" He was afraid. He asked God for signs: he put a sheep's fleece on the ground. One morning it was wet while the ground was dry, and the next morning it was dry while the ground was wet! God was patient with Gideon.
>
> Gideon gathered 32,000 men. But God said, "**Too many!** People will brag that they won by themselves." God sent most of them home until only **300** were left! God gave them a strange battle plan: each man held a **trumpet**, and a **torch hidden inside a clay jar**. In the middle of the night, they surrounded the enemy camp. Gideon gave the signal. CRASH went the jars! The torches blazed! The trumpets blared! They shouted, "**A sword for the LORD and for Gideon!**" The enemy was so confused they ran away. God won the battle!
>
> Then there was **Samson**. Before he was born, an angel told his parents that he would belong to God in a special way. He must never cut his hair. God gave Samson amazing strength: he tore apart a lion with his bare hands! But Samson often did whatever *he* wanted. He fell in love with a woman named **Delilah**, who worked for the enemy **Philistines**. She kept begging him to tell her the secret of his strength. Finally he told her, and while he slept, his hair was cut. The Philistines captured him and made him their prisoner. But Samson prayed one last time, "Lord, remember me. Give me strength just once more." God answered, and Samson pushed down the pillars of the enemy temple, defeating more enemies in his death than in his life.
>
> The book of Judges ends with sad words: "**In those days Israel had no king; everyone did as they saw fit**," meaning everyone did whatever they wanted. They needed a good King. And God was

> already planning one: first King David, and then the best King of all, **Jesus**, the perfect Rescuer who changes our hearts and breaks the circle of sin for good!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on Gideon. Give each child a paper cup "jar" with a paper flame inside and a cardboard-tube trumpet. Practice the shout: "For the LORD!" Big idea: "God helps us even when we feel small!"
- **Explorers:** Walk the cycle circle together, naming each step. Meet the three main judges with motions: Deborah (palm-tree arms), Gideon (trumpet and torch), Samson (strong arms).
- **Trailblazers:** Read Judges 2:10–19 and identify the cycle. Discuss: each judge had weaknesses. What does that show about our need for Jesus? Mention the other judges briefly (Othniel, Ehud, Shamgar, Tola, Jair, Jephthah, Ibzan, Elon, Abdon).
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Judges 2:10, "another generation grew up who knew neither the LORD nor what he had done." How does faith get passed (or lost) between generations? Read Judges 21:25 and connect it to today's "do whatever feels right" culture.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What did God's people do when they got in trouble? (Cried out to God) (2) How many men did Gideon have at the end? (300) (3) Who gave Samson his strength? (God!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What does a judge do in this book? (2) Why did God send most of Gideon's army home? (3) What was one good thing and one bad thing about Samson?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Name the five steps of the cycle. Have you ever been in a "cycle" with a bad habit? (2) Why was Gideon called "mighty warrior" when he was hiding? What does God see in us? (3) Why couldn't any judge fix the people for good?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Judges 2:10 describes a generation that didn't know God. What can your generation do differently? (2) "Everyone did as they saw fit." What happens to a society when that becomes the rule? (3) How is Jesus a better Savior than every judge?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Gideon" or "Samson" or "Deborah" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Gideon` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Gideon" or "Judges" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Gideon` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Judges" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Judges` |

Preview first. Judges videos can show battle scenes; choose carefully for younger groups. Follow-up questions: (1) What was the "cycle" the people kept repeating? (2) Why did they need a better King?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Gideon's Shrinking Army* and *Torch & Trumpet Night Tag*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Gideon's Jar & Torch* (younger) and *Judges Cycle Wheel* (older). See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Joshua 1:9 review. Spell **J-U-D-G-E-S** (remember the D!). Explorers: **G-I-D-E-O-N**, **S-A-M-S-O-N**, **D-E-B-O-R-A-H**. Trailblazers: **J-U-D-G-E**, **C-Y-C-L-E**, **D-E-L-I-V-E-R-E-R**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You that You hear us when we cry out to You. When we feel small like Gideon, remind us that You are with us. Thank You for Jesus, the perfect Rescuer and King who never fails. Amen.

Week 4: Loyal Love and a Redeemer 🌾

Scripture: Ruth 1:1–22; 2:1–23; 3:1–13 (summarized); 4:1–22

Lesson goal: Kids will learn how Ruth showed loyal love to Naomi and trusted God, how Boaz showed kindness and became their guardian-redeemer, and how their family led to King David and to Jesus, our Redeemer.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Stick Like Glue"

- *Supplies:* Two paper hearts, glue stick, a small bag of wheat stalks or uncooked rice/cereal; a "price tag."
- *Do:* Glue the two hearts together, then try to pull them apart (they tear!). "Some friends stick together no matter what. Ruth was a friend like that." Then show a price tag on a toy: "If I lost this and someone else had it, I could *buy it back*. That's called **redeeming**. In Ruth's story, someone redeems a whole family!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> During the days of the judges, there was a famine in Israel. There was no food! So a man named Elimelech, his wife **Naomi**, and their two sons left **Bethlehem** and moved to the country of **Moab**.
>
> While they were there, Elimelech died. The two sons married Moabite women named **Orpah** and **Ruth**. Then, very sadly, both sons died too. Naomi was left with no husband and no sons, just her two daughters-in-law.
>
> Naomi heard that God had given food back to Israel, so she decided to go home. She told Orpah and Ruth, "Go back to your mothers' homes." Orpah kissed her goodbye. But Ruth hugged Naomi tight and said, "**Where you go I will go, and where you stay I will stay. Your people will be my people and your God my God.**" Ruth chose to stay with Naomi, and to follow Naomi's God, the LORD.
>
> When they got to Bethlehem, Naomi was so sad she said, "Don't call me Naomi (which means *pleasant*). Call me **Mara** (which means *bitter*)." It was the start of the barley harvest.
>
> To get food, Ruth went to **glean**: walking behind the harvesters and picking up the leftover grain they dropped. God's law said farmers should leave some for poor people and foreigners. Ruth "happened" to go to the field of a kind man named **Boaz**, who was a relative of Naomi's husband! Boaz greeted his workers, "The LORD be with you!" He saw Ruth and said, "I've heard how kind

you've been to Naomi. May the LORD, under whose wings you've come to find safety, reward you!" He told his workers to drop extra grain on purpose for her, and he gave her lunch.

Naomi was amazed. "Boaz is one of our family's **guardian-redeemers**!" A guardian-redeemer was a close relative who could buy back a family's land and take care of a widow's family so the family name wouldn't be lost.

Ruth asked Boaz to be their redeemer, and Boaz said yes! But there was one closer relative who had the first chance. So Boaz went to the town gate and asked him in front of the leaders. The man said, "I can't do it." He took off his sandal and gave it to Boaz. That's how people sealed a deal back then!

So Boaz **redeemed** Naomi's family land and married Ruth. God gave them a baby boy named **Obed**. Naomi held him and wasn't bitter anymore. The women said, "Praise the LORD!" Obed grew up and became the father of **Jesse**, and Jesse was the father of... **King David**!

And many years later, from that same family, in that same town of Bethlehem, **Jesus** was born. Jesus is our **Redeemer**. He paid the price, His own life, to bring us back into God's family. And just like Ruth, anyone from any nation can come and find safety under God's wings.

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Scatter paper "grain" on the floor. Kids gather it like Ruth, while a "Boaz" helper secretly drops extra. Repeat the motion and words: "Where you go, I will go!" (point and walk) and "Boaz was kind!" (hug).
- **Explorers:** Act out the story in 4 scenes (one per chapter) with simple costumes, including the sandal at the gate! Talk about how Ruth "happened" to find Boaz's field (2:3) and how God was guiding her.
- **Trailblazers:** Teach the word *hesed* (loyal love) and find it in Ruth 1:8; 2:20; 3:10. Draw the family tree from Ruth and Boaz to David (4:17–22), then show Matthew 1:5–6.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss how Ruth, a Moabite, is welcomed into Israel (compare Deuteronomy 23:3 and how grace goes beyond expectations). Discuss God's "hidden" work: He's never mentioned doing a miracle in Ruth, yet He's guiding everything.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who did Ruth stay with? (Naomi) (2) What did Ruth pick up in the field? (Grain / wheat) (3) Who was kind to Ruth? (Boaz)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did Ruth promise Naomi? (2) How did Boaz show kindness? (3) Ruth's great-grandson became a famous king. Who was he?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) What does "redeemer" mean? How is Jesus our Redeemer? (2) Ruth "happened" to come to Boaz's field. Do you think it was an accident? (3) How did Naomi change from the beginning to the end of the story?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) What does Ruth's story teach about loyalty in friendships and family? (2) How does God work in ordinary life when there are no big miracles? Where have you seen that? (3) Why is it significant that a foreigner from Moab is in the family line of Jesus?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Ruth" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Ruth` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Ruth" or "Ruth and Boaz" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Ruth` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Ruth"; theme video "Messiah" (optional) | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Ruth` |

Preview first. Follow-up questions: (1) How did Ruth show loyal love? (2) How is Boaz like Jesus?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Ruth's Gleaning Grab*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Wheat Sheaf Craft* and *Ruth-to-Jesus Family Tree*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Say Joshua 1:9 from memory. Spell **R-U-T-H**, **N-A-O-M-I**, **B-O-A-Z**. Trailblazers / Ambassadors: **R-E-D-E-E-M-E-R**, **B-E-T-H-L-E-H-E-M**, **L-O-Y-A-L-T-Y**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You for Your loyal love that never lets us go. Help us be kind and loyal friends like Ruth and Boaz. Thank You for Jesus, our Redeemer, who brings us into Your family. Amen.

Week 5 (optional): Review & Fun Sunday 🎉

Use the **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration** plan below.

Book Memory Song & Motions 🎵

This song **builds on** Phases 1 and 2. Always sing from the beginning: Library → Law → History!

Part A (review from Phase 1): "The Bible Library Song" (tune: *Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star*)

> 🎵 Sixty-six books, one big story, / All about God and all His glory! / Thirty-nine are in the Old, / Twenty-seven New, we're told. / Sixty-six books, one big story, / All about God and all His glory!

Part B (review from Phase 2): "The Law Song" (tune: *Ten Little Fingers*)

> 🎵 Gen-e-sis, Ex-o-dus, Le-vit-i-cus, / Num-bers and Deu-ter-on-o-my, / God gave His Word to Mo-ses, / Five books of the LAW!

Part C (NEW): "History Starts Here" (tune: *London Bridge Is Falling Down*)

Verse 1, the books:

> 🎵 **Josh-u-a, Judg-es, then comes Ruth,** *(march and trumpet → gavel → gather and hug)* **Then comes Ruth, then comes Ruth;** *(gather and hug, twice)* **Josh-u-a, Judg-es, then comes Ruth:** *(repeat motions)* **His-to-ry starts here!** *(point down at the floor on "here!")*

Verse 2, Joshua:

> 🎵 **Jericho walls came falling down,** *(hands high like a wall, then let them tumble down)* **Falling down, falling down; "Be strong and brave, God's always 'round!"** *(flex arms, then point up)* **Joshua one-nine!** *(hold up 1 finger, then 9 fingers)*

Verse 3, Judges:

> 🎵 **Round and round the people went,** *(draw a big circle in the air)* **People went, people went; They cried to God and judges were sent:** *(hands cupped at mouth, then gavel)* **Gideon, Deborah, Samson!** *(trumpet, palm-tree arms, strong arms)*

Verse 4, Ruth:

> 🎵 **"Where you go, I'll go," said Ruth,** *(point forward, walk fingers)* **Said to Naomi, loyal and true;** *(hug yourself)* **Boaz redeemed her (Jesus does too!),** *(arms wide, then point up)* **Great-grandma of David!** *(make a crown on your head)*

The "Eight Books" chant (steady clap)

> **Five books of LAW** *(clap-clap-clap)*: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy! **Three books of HISTORY** *(stomp-stomp-stomp)*: Joshua, Judges, Ruth! **Five plus three is EIGHT!** *(hold up 5 fingers + 3 fingers)*: **EIGHT of SIXTY-SIX!**

Hand motions for all 8 books

#	Book	Motion	One word
1	Genesis	🌅 Sunrise hands	Beginnings
2	Exodus	🚪 Fingers walk out the door	Rescue
3	Leviticus	🙏 Fold hands, raise high	Holy

#	Book	Motion	One word
4	Numbers	🔢 Count, then zig-zag	Wilderness
5	Deuteronomy	✌️🧠❤️ Two fingers, tap head, hand on heart	Remember
6	Joshua	🎺 March in place with a fist trumpet	Conquer
7	Judges	🔨 Fist on palm, then a circle in the air	Cycle
8	Ruth	🌾 Scoop grain, then hug yourself	Loyalty

Section Shout

> **Teacher:** "What's the FIRST section?" **Kids:** "**LAW!** Five books!" *(5 fingers)* **Teacher:** "What's the SECOND section?" **Kids:** "**HISTORY!** Twelve books!" *(10 fingers + 2)* **Teacher:** "How many History books do we know?" **Kids:** "**THREE!** Joshua, Judges, Ruth!" **Teacher:** "How many more to go?" **Kids:** "**NINE** more next time!"

Cumulative recall drill

1. Sing Parts A, B and C (verse 1) straight through with motions.
2. **Motion-only round:** the teacher does only the motions, silently; kids call out the book names.
3. **Book-before / book-after:** "What comes after Deuteronomy?" (Joshua) "What comes before Ruth?" (Judges)
4. **Section sort:** call a book; kids shout "LAW!" or "HISTORY!"
5. **One-word round** for all 8 books.
6. **Bible facts** from Phase 1: 66 / 39 / 27; chapter versus verse; the Contents trick.
7. **Sword drill:** Joshua 1:9; Judges 21:25; Ruth 1:16.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Aim to say "Joshua, Judges, Ruth" with motions, and "LAW" and "HISTORY" as section names. The London Bridge tune is easy for them!
- **Explorers:** Say all 8 books in order and spell Joshua, Judges and Ruth. Lead the "Eight Books" chant.
- **Trailblazers:** Say all 8 forwards and backwards with one-word summaries. Add the 12 judges as a bonus chant.
- **Ambassadors:** Lead Parts A–C for the younger kids. Challenge: name all 12 History books in order as a preview (Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1 & 2 Samuel, 1 & 2 Kings, 1 & 2 Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther).

Spelling & Reading 🔤

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letters and sounds)	Explorers (book names and story words)	Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab)	Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab)
J is for **J**oshua, **J**udges and **J**ericho	JOSHUA	All 8: GENESIS → RUTH	All 8: GENESIS → RUTH
R is for **R**uth and **R**ahab	JUDGES	**Vocab:** COURAGEOUS, JERICHO, JUDGE, REDEEMER, GLEAN	**Vocab:** CONQUEST, DELIVERER, NAZIRITE, HESED, GUARDIAN-REDEEMER
G is for **G**ideon	RUTH		
B is for **B**oaz	GIDEON		
Sound it out: *R-u-th* "Ruth"	SAMSON		
Trace: R-U-T-H	RAHAB, CALEB, NAOMI		
Clap it: Josh-u-a (3)	JERICHO		

Ambassadors vocab with definitions:

- **Conquest:** taking control of a land by force; in Joshua, God giving Canaan to Israel as He promised and judging the Canaanites' long-standing evil.
- **Deliverer:** one who rescues; the Bible's word for what a judge did (Judges 3:9, 15). Jesus is the ultimate Deliverer (1 Thessalonians 1:10).
- **Nazirite:** a person set apart to God by a special vow: no haircuts, no wine or grapes, no touching dead bodies (Numbers 6). Samson was one from birth (Judges 13:5).
- **Hesed** (HEH-sed): Hebrew for loyal, covenant, never-giving-up love; shown by Ruth, Boaz and, most of all, God.
- **Guardian-redeemer** (Hebrew *go'el*): a close relative responsible for buying back family land or people and protecting the family line (Leviticus 25:25; Ruth 3:9).

The syllable-clap method 👏

Word	Claps	Parts → letters
Joshua	3	Josh (J-O-S-H) · u (U) · a (A)
Judges	2	Judg (J-U-D-G) · es (E-S)
Ruth	1	Ruth (R-U-T-H)
Jericho	3	Jer (J-E-R) · i (I) · cho (C-H-O)

Word	Claps	Parts → letters
Gideon	3	Gid (G-I-D) · e (E) · on (O-N)
Redeemer	3	Re (R-E) · deem (D-E-E-M) · er (E-R)

Tips: **Judges** has a sneaky silent **D**: "jud-ges." **Joshua** ends with **U-A**, not "-ua" sounding like "wah." **Ruth** rhymes with "truth," and Ruth told Naomi the truth about being loyal!

"Spell It Out" relay, Jericho style

- **Setup:** Teams; letter cards for each word are taped on cardboard boxes stacked into a "wall" at the far end.
- **Play:** Runners march (no running!) to the wall, take one letter card from a box, and march back. When a team's word is complete and in order, they blow paper trumpets and shout the word. Then they get to knock down their wall!
- **Words:** JOSHUA, JUDGES, RUTH, RAHAB (Explorers); JERICHO, GIDEON, REDEEMER (Trailblazers); NAZIRITE, CONQUEST, DELIVERER (Ambassadors).
- **Little Lambs:** Find the letters J, J, R (the first letters of the three new books) and the letters of R-U-T-H.

Mini spelling bee word list (with sentences)

Word	Use it in a sentence
Joshua	*Joshua* led God's people into the Promised Land.
Judges	The book of *Judges* shows God sending rescuers again and again.
Ruth	*Ruth* said, "Your God will be my God."
Jericho	The walls of *Jericho* fell down flat.
Rahab	*Rahab* hung a scarlet cord in her window.
Caleb	*Caleb* was still strong at 85 years old.
Gideon	*Gideon* had only 300 men, but God won the battle.
Deborah	*Deborah* was a judge and a prophet.
Samson	God gave *Samson* great strength.
Naomi	*Naomi* came home to Bethlehem.
Boaz	*Boaz* was kind to Ruth.
courageous	God told Joshua, "Be strong and *courageous*."
redeemer	Jesus is our *Redeemer*.
Bethlehem	Ruth and Boaz lived in *Bethlehem*.
Nazirite	Samson was a *Nazirite*, set apart for God.

Read-aloud practice passage (Ruth 1:16–17, NIV)

> "But Ruth replied, 'Don't urge me to leave you or to turn back from you. Where you go I will go, and where you stay I will stay. Your people will be my people and your God my God. Where you die I will die, and there I will be buried. May the LORD deal with me, be it ever so severely, if even death separates you and me.'"

Reading tips: Read it like Ruth, with a strong, loyal voice. Notice the pairs: go / go, stay / stay, people / people, God / God. Have kids read it in pairs, one reading "Where you go," the other answering "I will go." Second passage (Explorers+): Joshua 1:9, read three times, getting louder each time like the Jericho shout!

Word Trivia ❓

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. Who became the leader of God's people after Moses?
2. What color was the cord Rahab hung in her window?
3. What fell down when the people shouted?
4. **Fill in the blank:** "Be strong and _____."
5. What river did God's people cross on dry ground?
6. How many times did they march around Jericho on the seventh day?
7. Who was very strong because God gave him strength?
8. **True or False:** Gideon had a really big army when he won the battle.
9. Who said, "Where you go I will go"?
10. What did Ruth gather in Boaz's field?
11. Who was Ruth's mother-in-law?
12. Which famous king was Ruth's great-grandson?

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. Name the 8 books we've learned so far, in order.
14. What does the name "Joshua" mean?
15. How many stones were taken out of the Jordan River?
16. **Who said it?** "As for me and my household, we will serve the LORD."
17. **Which book?** Gideon and Samson are found in which book?
18. How many men were left in Gideon's army?
19. What did Gideon's men carry into the battle?
20. **True or False:** Deborah was a judge and a prophet.
21. Who hid two spies on her roof?
22. How old was Caleb when he asked for his mountain?
23. What did the closer relative give Boaz to seal the deal?

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

24. What are the five steps of the Judges cycle?
25. Name at least six of the 12 judges.
26. **Fill in the blank:** "In those days Israel had no _____; everyone did as they saw _____." (Judges 21:25)
27. What did Achan take and hide?
28. What does "guardian-redeemer" mean?
29. What special vow did Samson have from birth, and what was its sign?
30. **Who said it?** "The LORD is with you, mighty warrior." (Judges 6:12)
31. Which two women from these books are listed in Jesus' family tree in Matthew 1?
32. **Fill in the blank:** "Not one of all the LORD's good _____ to Israel failed; every one was _____." (Joshua 21:45)
33. What does the Hebrew word *hesed* mean?
34. What was the name of Ruth's son, and who was his grandson?
35. What happened to the Jordan River when the priests' feet touched the water?

🔑 Answer Key

1. Joshua · 2. Red (scarlet) · 3. The walls of Jericho · 4. courageous · 5. The Jordan River · 6. Seven · 7. Samson · 8. False (only 300 men) · 9. Ruth · 10. Grain (barley and wheat) · 11. Naomi · 12. King David
2. Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, Joshua, Judges, Ruth · 14. "The LORD saves" · 15. Twelve · 16. Joshua (Joshua 24:15) · 17. Judges · 18. 300 · 19. Trumpets, and torches inside clay jars · 20. True (Judges 4:4) · 21. Rahab · 22. 85 · 23. His sandal
3. Sin, Suffer, Shout (cry out), Savior (a judge is sent), Silence (peace), and then repeat · 25. Othniel, Ehud, Shamgar, Deborah, Gideon, Tola, Jair, Jephthah, Ibzan, Elon, Abdon, Samson · 26. king / fit · 27. A beautiful robe, 200 shekels of silver and a bar of gold (Joshua 7:21) · 28. A close relative who buys back family land or people and protects the family · 29. The Nazirite vow; never cutting his hair · 30. The angel of the LORD · 31. Rahab and Ruth (Matthew 1:5) · 32. promises / fulfilled · 33. Loyal, faithful, covenant love · 34. Obed; David (Obed → Jesse → David) · 35. It stopped flowing and piled up upstream so the people crossed on dry ground (Joshua 3:15–17)

Games 🎮

(More games and variations: `../00-start-here/game-library.md`)

1. Jericho Walls

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** 20+ cardboard boxes or plastic cups for a "wall"; paper trumpets or kazoos; a "trumpet" signal (a whistle or a real trumpet sound on a phone).
- **Setup:** Build the wall in the center of the room. Kids line up behind a "priest" (an Ambassador holding a toy "ark," such as a decorated box on two poles).

- **How to play:** Kids march around the wall in silence (Joshua 6:10) as you count "Day 1, Day 2..." up to Day 6 (one lap each). On Day 7 they march 7 laps. On the long trumpet blast, everyone shouts, and a helper knocks the wall down. Then rebuild, and on the second round, each lap requires a kid to say one book name in order (Genesis through Ruth, then start again).
- **How to win:** It's a celebration game: everyone wins when the wall falls! Optional: time the second round to beat your record.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* fewer laps (Day 7 = 3 laps) and lots of shouting. *Ambassadors:* they lead, and each lap they must quote a promise of God.
- **Learning goal:** The Jericho story; obedience and faith; book-name review.

2. Crossing the Jordan

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** Blue tarp or blue paper "river"; 12 paper "stones" (gray paper plates) each with a review question on the back.
- **Setup:** Lay the river across the room; place the 12 stones inside it as stepping stones.
- **How to play:** Teams take turns. To step on a stone, a player picks it up, answers its question, and if correct, places it on the far bank to build the "memorial pile." Wrong answers: the stone stays, and the next player tries.
- **How to win:** When all 12 stones are on the far bank, the whole class has "crossed" and shouts "God stopped the river!" For competition, use two rivers and race.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* questions are pictures ("Who is this?") or "Say a book name." *Ambassadors:* questions from the ⭐⭐⭐ list.
- **Learning goal:** The Jordan crossing; remembering God's faithfulness.

3. Rahab's Rescue Rope

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers (Little Lambs as "family members").
- **Supplies:** A long red ribbon or rope; a "window" (a hula hoop held up, or a doorway).
- **Setup:** One child is Rahab, holding the red cord in the "window." Two players are "spies." Several "soldiers of Jericho" are taggers.
- **How to play:** The spies must reach Rahab's window without being tagged. If they make it, Rahab "lets them down" (they walk through the hoop). Then Rahab's family members (the rest of the kids) must also reach the red cord. Anyone touching the red cord is safe and can't be tagged.
- **How to win:** Once everyone's holding the red cord, read Joshua 6:25: "Joshua spared Rahab... and all who belonged to her."
- **Adaptation:** *Older kids:* players must say a book name or Bible fact before they can grab the cord.
- **Learning goal:** Rahab's faith and rescue; salvation for all who trust.

4. Twelve Stones Stepping Race

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors.
- **Supplies:** For each team, 12 paper "stones," each labeled with one of the 12 tribes of Israel or, for younger kids, with book names in order.
- **Setup:** Teams line up; stones piled at the start.

- **How to play:** The first player places a stone a step ahead and steps on it; each next player places the next stone in order (Genesis, Exodus... or the tribes: Reuben, Simeon, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun, Benjamin, Dan, Naphtali, Gad, Asher, Ephraim, Manasseh). Players may only move on stones. The whole team must cross the "river" using the stone path.
- **How to win:** First team across with stones in the correct order.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* stepping-stone path with pictures, no order needed. *Ambassadors:* tribes in the order of Joshua 13–19, or the 12 sons of Jacob.
- **Learning goal:** Teamwork; book order; the 12 tribes.

5. Gideon's Shrinking Army

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** None (optional: paper cups of water for the "drinking test").
- **Setup:** All kids stand in an open space as "Gideon's army." A leader is "Gideon."
- **How to play:** Like "Simon Says," but Gideon says "**God says...**" Round 1: "Anyone afraid, go home!" (Judges 7:3; everyone who giggles goes to the side.) Then quick commands: "God says march!", "God says blow your trumpet!", "Shout!" (Without "God says," anyone who moves sits out.) Keep going until only a few are left: "Now there are just enough for God to win the battle!"
- **How to win:** The last few players lead the final victory shout: "**A sword for the LORD and for Gideon!**" Then explain: "God made the army small so everyone would know *He* won."
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* simple commands and quick restarts. *Older kids:* commands include Bible facts ("God says hop if Gideon was a judge!").
- **Learning goal:** Listening to God; God's strength in our weakness (2 Corinthians 12:9).

6. Torch & Trumpet Night Tag

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors.
- **Supplies:** Flashlights (torches) hidden in paper bags or under cups (jars); a room that can be darkened safely; glow sticks for "Midianites."
- **Setup:** Turn the lights down (not fully dark; keep it safe). "Midianites" wearing glow sticks hide around the room. Gideon's team of "300" holds covered flashlights.
- **How to play:** On "Now!", the team lifts their cups (revealing the light), shouts "For the LORD and for Gideon!" and "tags" Midianites with flashlight beams. Tagged Midianites must sit down.
- **How to win:** Gideon's team wins when all Midianites are tagged; then switch roles.
- **Adaptation:** *Ambassadors:* run it for younger kids, with careful supervision. Keep lights partly on for anxious kids.
- **Learning goal:** The Gideon story; God gives victory.

7. Ruth's Gleaning Grab

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers (older kids as "Boaz's workers").
- **Supplies:** Yellow paper strips or pipe cleaners ("barley"), a few gold-colored strips (bonus "extra from Boaz"), a basket per child.
- **Setup:** "Harvesters" (older kids or helpers) walk across the "field," dropping barley strips. "Ruths" follow behind.

- **How to play:** Ruths may only pick up what's dropped *behind* the harvesters. Boaz (a teacher) secretly tells harvesters to "drop extra on purpose" (Ruth 2:16): gold strips.
- **How to win:** At the end, everyone counts their barley. Gold strips are worth 5. Everyone shares their gleanings so that all baskets are equal: "Boaz was kind and generous!"
- **Adaptation:** *Older kids:* each gold strip has a trivia question; answer it to keep the 5 points.
- **Learning goal:** Ruth's story; kindness and generosity to those in need.

8. History Shelf Hop (review game)

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** Painter's tape for a hopscotch grid of 8 squares, labeled with the 8 books in order (Law squares one color, History squares another).
- **How to play:** Kids hop through saying each book as they land. On the way back, they say the one-word summary. A tossed beanbag marks a square; when you land there, do that book's motion.
- **How to win:** Complete the hop with no mistakes for a sticker. Add more squares each phase!
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* hop with a buddy who says the names with them. *Ambassadors:* say the book's key person on every square.
- **Learning goal:** Cumulative book order (8 of 66).

Coloring Pages 🖍️

> Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-03-printables.html`

Page 1: The Walls of Jericho Fall (Week 1)

- **Scene:** Big stone walls tumbling down with bricks flying (no people hurt); seven priests in robes blowing long, curly ram's-horn trumpets; Joshua in front with arms raised; one section of the wall still standing with a window and a red cord hanging out (Rahab's house!).
- **Caption:** *"Be strong and courageous." Joshua 1:9*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Can you find Rahab's window? What color is the cord? Why did the walls fall down? What's a 'wall' (a big problem) you need God's help with?"

Page 2: Crossing the Jordan and the 12 Stones (Week 1)

- **Scene:** Priests standing in a dry riverbed holding the gold ark of the covenant on poles; water piled up in the distance; families crossing; 12 men each carrying a big stone on their shoulder.
- **Caption:** *"What do these stones mean?" Joshua 4:6*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Count the stones! What does your family 'remember' about God's goodness?"

Page 3: "As for Me and My House" (Week 2)

- **Scene:** A house with an open door, a family (parents, kids, grandparents, a pet) standing together in front; a big stone under a tree beside them; old Caleb waving from a hill in the background.
- **Caption:** *"As for me and my household, we will serve the LORD." Joshua 24:15*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Draw your own family members in the doorway! What's one way your family serves God?"

Page 4: Gideon's 300 (Week 3)

- **Scene:** Nighttime on a hill; men holding ram's-horn trumpets in one hand and broken clay jars with bright torches in the other; the enemy camp of tents below in confusion; a moon and stars.
- **Caption:** *"The LORD is with you, mighty warrior." Judges 6:12*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Use bright colors for the torches! God called scared Gideon 'mighty warrior.' What do you think God sees in you?"

Page 5: Deborah under the Palm Tree / Samson (Week 3, optional)

- **Scene (left):** Deborah sitting under a big palm tree helping people who came to her. **(Right):** Strong Samson pushing two temple pillars apart.
- **Caption:** *"They cried out to the LORD, and he raised up for them a deliverer." Judges 3:9*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Who gave Deborah wisdom and Samson strength? Who is our perfect Deliverer?"

Page 6: Ruth Gleaning in Boaz's Field (Week 4)

- **Scene:** Golden fields of grain; workers harvesting with sickles; Ruth with a basket picking up stalks; Boaz, kind and smiling, pointing workers to drop extra; Naomi in the distance near Bethlehem's walls.
- **Caption:** *"Where you go I will go… your God my God." Ruth 1:16*
- **Coloring conversation:** "How did Ruth show loyal love? Who can you be a loyal friend to this week?"

Page 7: History Begins! (book-name page)

- **Scene:** A bookshelf with the 5 Law books already "colored in" (filled with stripes), then three new books in bubble letters: JOSHUA (trumpet and walls), JUDGES (gavel and circle arrow), RUTH (wheat sheaf and heart). Banner: "8 of 66 · LAW ✔ · HISTORY 3 of 12."
- **Caption:** *"Joshua, Judges, then comes Ruth!"*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Can you name all eight books on the shelf? How many History books are left to learn? (9!)"

Activities & Crafts ✂️

1. Jericho Trumpet (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Paper-towel tubes or rolled paper cones, gold or brown paint/markers, curling ribbon, stickers, tape.
- **Steps:** (1) Roll a sheet of paper into a cone (or use a tube) and tape it. (2) Decorate it like a ram's horn with stripes. (3) Add ribbons coming out of the wide end. (4) Write "Be strong and courageous! Joshua 1:9" along the side.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* pre-rolled tubes; stickers and crayons. *Older kids:* draw seven marks on it (seven trumpets, seven days, seven laps) and write the book names Genesis–Ruth around the horn.
- **What it teaches:** Faith and obedience in the Jericho story; courage in God's presence.

2. Rahab's Scarlet Cord Window (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Brown cardstock (the wall), a window cut-out (fold-open shutters), red yarn, glue, markers.
- **Steps:** (1) Draw bricks on the cardstock. (2) Cut a window with shutters that open. (3) Inside the window, draw Rahab's family. (4) Glue red yarn hanging out of the window. (5) Write "Rahab trusted God and was saved. Hebrews 11:31."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* pre-cut windows; glue on the yarn and draw faces. *Ambassadors:* add a note connecting the red cord, the Passover blood and Jesus' blood.
- **What it teaches:** Salvation by faith; God welcomes anyone who trusts Him.

3. Memorial Stones (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Smooth rocks (one or more per child), acrylic paint pens or markers, sealer spray (optional, done by an adult).
- **Steps:** (1) On one rock, write or draw something God has done for you or your family (Little Lambs: a heart or a smiley). (2) On the back, write "Joshua 4:7." (3) Older kids make 12 small stones, one for each "God did it!" memory.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* paint with fingers or dot markers; the teacher writes. *Ambassadors:* write a testimony sentence to share with the class.
- **What it teaches:** Remembering and telling God's faithfulness to the next generation.

4. "As for Me and My House" Door Hanger (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Door-hanger shapes cut from cardstock (or paper plates with a hole), markers, stickers, ribbon.
- **Steps:** (1) Write Joshua 24:15b: "As for me and my household, we will serve the LORD." (2) Draw your family. (3) On the back, list 3 ways your family can serve God this week (pray at dinner, help a neighbor, give to someone in need).
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* the teacher pre-writes; kids decorate and add a family picture. *Older kids:* use calligraphy or bubble lettering.
- **What it teaches:** Choosing to serve God as an individual and a family.

5. Gideon's Jar & Torch (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Paper or plastic cups (the "jars"), yellow, orange and red tissue paper, craft sticks, tape; optional battery tea lights.
- **Steps:** (1) Glue tissue "flames" onto a craft stick (or use a tea light). (2) Decorate the outside of the cup like a clay jar. (3) Hide the torch inside the cup. (4) Write on the cup: "The LORD is with you, mighty warrior! Judges 6:12." (5) Practice the reveal: lift the cup, shout "For the LORD!"
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* pre-made flames. *Ambassadors:* connect it to 2 Corinthians 4:6–7 ("treasure in jars of clay"): God's light shines through ordinary people.
- **What it teaches:** God uses small and weak people for His glory.

6. Judges Cycle Wheel (Week 3, Explorers and older)

- **Supplies:** Two paper plates, a brass fastener, markers.
- **Steps:** (1) Divide the bottom plate into 5 sections: SIN (an idol), SUFFER (a sad face), SHOUT (hands up), SAVIOR (a judge), SILENCE / peace (a dove). (2) Cut a window in the top plate. (3) Fasten together and spin to show the cycle. (4) On the top plate write: "Jesus breaks the cycle! Judges 21:25 → John 8:36."
- **Age adaptations:** *Explorers:* pre-labeled sections, they draw pictures. *Ambassadors:* add the names of the judges around the edge in order.
- **What it teaches:** The pattern of Judges and our need for Jesus.

7. Wheat Sheaf Craft (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Yellow construction paper strips, brown yarn or ribbon, glue, cardstock backing; optional real wheat stalks (from a craft store).
- **Steps:** (1) Fringe-cut the yellow strips at the top for grain heads. (2) Bundle them and tie them in the middle with yarn. (3) Glue the sheaf to cardstock and write "Ruth 1:16" and "God provides through kind people."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* glue pre-cut strips. *Older kids:* write the name of someone they can be kind to this week, like Boaz.
- **What it teaches:** Loyal love, kindness and God's provision.

8. Ruth-to-Jesus Family Tree (Week 4, Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

- **Supplies:** Large paper, markers, Bibles open to Ruth 4:13–22 and Matthew 1:1–6, 16.
- **Steps:** (1) Draw a tree. (2) At the roots, write Abraham. (3) Up the trunk: Judah… Salmon + **Rahab** → Boaz + **Ruth** → Obed → Jesse → **David**. (4) At the top of the tree, write **Jesus** (Matthew 1:16). (5) Mark Rahab and Ruth with hearts: two women from outside Israel, welcomed by grace!
- **Age adaptations:** *Explorers:* fill in a pre-drawn tree with name stickers.
- **What it teaches:** God's big plan to bring Jesus; His grace for all nations.

Word Puzzles 🧩

Word Scramble

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	HUSAJO	Book 6, leader after Moses
2	SEDGUJ	Book 7, the "cycle" book
3	HURT	Book 8, loyal love
4	CHOJIRE	City whose walls fell
5	BAHAR	Hung a scarlet cord
6	BACLE	Strong at 85
7	DONIGE	Had 300 men
8	HADROBE	Judge under a palm tree
9	MASNOS	Strongest judge
10	MIANO	Ruth's mother-in-law
11	ZOBA	Kind guardian-redeemer
12	DRAJON	River that stopped flowing
13	MEDEERER	One who buys back
14	SOURCEGUAO	"Be strong and _____"

🔑 **Answers:** 1. JOSHUA · 2. JUDGES · 3. RUTH · 4. JERICHO · 5. RAHAB · 6. CALEB · 7. GIDEON · 8. DEBORAH · 9. SAMSON · 10. NAOMI · 11. BOAZ · 12. JORDAN · 13. REDEEMER · 14. COURAGEOUS

Fill-in-the-Blank Story

Word bank: courageous, Jordan, red, seven, serve, judges, 300, Samson, Naomi, Boaz, David, Jesus

> God told Joshua, "Be strong and **(1)**." God stopped the **(2)** River so the people could cross. Rahab hung a **(3)** cord in her window. On the seventh day, the people marched around Jericho **(4)** times, and the walls fell! Joshua said, "As for me and my household, we will **(5)** the LORD." After Joshua died, God sent rescuers called **(6)**. Gideon won a battle with only **(7)** men. God gave **(8)** great strength. Ruth stayed with her mother-in-law, **(9)**. A kind man named **(10)** became Ruth's redeemer. Their great-grandson was King **(11)**. And from their family came **(12)**, our Redeemer!

🔑 **Answers:** 1. courageous · 2. Jordan · 3. red · 4. seven · 5. serve · 6. judges · 7. 300 · 8. Samson · 9. Naomi · 10. Boaz · 11. David · 12. Jesus

Match the Book to Its Picture / Summary

Book	Picture / summary
1. Deuteronomy	A. 🌾 A loyal widow, a kind redeemer, a baby in David's family
2. Joshua	B. 🔨🔄 Round and round: sin, suffer, shout, Savior, silence
3. Judges	C. ❤️ Moses' farewell: "Love the LORD your God"
4. Ruth	D. 🎺 Walls fall down, the river stops, "Be strong and courageous"
5. Genesis	E. 🌅 Creation, the flood, Abraham, Joseph
6. Exodus	F. 🚪🌊 Plagues, Passover, the Red Sea, the Ten Commandments

🔑 **Answers:** 1-C · 2-D · 3-B · 4-A · 5-E · 6-F

Questions for Every Age 💭

Little Lambs (4–6)

1. When do you feel scared? Who is always with you?
2. What did God do to the walls of Jericho?
3. How did Gideon's tiny army win?
4. How was Ruth a good friend?
5. How can you be kind like Boaz this week?

Explorers (7–10)

1. What does it mean to be "strong and courageous" at school?
2. Achan hid what he took. Why is it better to tell the truth when we do wrong?
3. What's a "cycle" you sometimes get stuck in (like losing your temper)? How can God help?
4. God used a scared farmer (Gideon). What does that tell you about how God can use you?
5. Who in your life is loyal like Ruth? How can you thank them?

Trailblazers (11–13)

1. Joshua 1:9 says God is with you "wherever you go." Where do you most need to remember that?
2. Caleb followed God wholeheartedly for 45+ years. What helps someone stay faithful for a lifetime?
3. Why do you think every judge had flaws? What does that teach about human heroes?
4. "Everyone did as they saw fit" (Judges 21:25). Where do you see that attitude today?
5. In Ruth, God never does a big miracle, yet He's working everywhere. How might God be working quietly in your life?

Ambassadors (14–17)

1. Joshua 24:15 is a personal choice. Have you made that choice for yourself? What would it look like to say it out loud?
2. How does Rahab's story challenge the idea that some people are "too far gone" for God?
3. What lessons from Samson's life apply to gifted, talented people today?
4. Judges 2:10 describes a generation that didn't know God. What can you do to help younger kids know Him? (You're doing it now!)
5. How is Jesus a better Joshua, a better Judge and a better Boaz?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. **"How could a loving God command the destruction of the Canaanites?"** *Suggested answer:* This is a hard question, and it's okay to wrestle with it. Some things to consider: (a) It was **judgment** for centuries of serious evil, including child sacrifice (Deuteronomy 12:31; 18:9–12), after God had waited over 400 years (Genesis 15:16). (b) It was **limited** to a specific time and place, not a permanent command for God's people to fight anyone. (c) God **judged Israel too** when it did the same evil (2 Kings 17). (d) **Mercy was available:** Rahab and the Gibeonites turned to God and were spared. (e) Ancient war reports often used exaggerated, sweeping language ("left no survivors"), and later passages show Canaanites still living there (Judges 1). (f) Ultimately, the cross shows God taking judgment on Himself so that people from every nation, including Canaanites, can be saved. Christians are never called to "holy war"; Jesus says to love our enemies (Matthew 5:44).
2. **"Is the Bible just a book of moral heroes? Many of these people are pretty bad."** *Suggested answer:* The Bible isn't mainly about heroes to copy; it's about a God who rescues flawed people. Gideon doubted and later made an idol; Samson was selfish; Israel kept forgetting God. The Bible is brutally honest about its people, which is one reason to trust it. Myths usually make their heroes look good. The real hero of every story is God, and every flawed rescuer points to Jesus, the only perfect Savior.
3. **"Why does it matter that Rahab and Ruth are in Jesus' family tree?"** *Suggested answer:* Both were outsiders. Rahab was a Canaanite with a sinful past and Ruth was a Moabite, from nations considered enemies of Israel. Their inclusion shows that God's plan was always for "all peoples on earth" (Genesis 12:3), that grace isn't earned by background or record, and that Jesus came for everyone. It also shows that the Bible's genealogy isn't a cleaned-up royal record; it's honest, and full of grace.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration 🎉

Review game plan (last Sunday of the month, 75 minutes)

Time	Activity
10 min	Welcome + sing Parts A, B and C with motions; "Eight Books" chant; Section Shout

Time	Activity
15 min	**Promised Land Game Show:** teams answer trivia; each correct answer earns a paper stone to build their "memorial pile." The tallest pile wins
10 min	**Jericho Walls Finale:** march 7 laps saying all 8 books (one book per lap, plus a final shout of all 8)
10 min	**History Shelf Hop** relay (8-square hopscotch)
15 min	**Oral check-offs** while others color Page 7 or finish the Family Tree
10 min	**Passport stamping & badge ceremony**: blow paper trumpets as each name is called!
5 min	Everyone says Joshua 1:9 together; prayer; Take-Home Family Page

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (4–6) ☐ Say the section names "LAW" and "HISTORY" ☐ Say "Joshua, Judges, Ruth" with motions ☐ Say "Be strong and courageous." ☐ Tell one story (Jericho, Gideon or Ruth) in one sentence ☐ Review: "The Bible has 66 books; Genesis is first"

Explorers (7–10) ☐ Say all 8 books in order ☐ Spell Joshua, Judges and Ruth ☐ Say Joshua 1:9 ☐ Name 3 judges ☐ Find Joshua 1:9 and Ruth 1:16 using the Contents page

Trailblazers (11–13) ☐ Say all 8 books forwards and backwards with a one-word summary for each ☐ Spell all 8 books ☐ Say Joshua 1:9 ☐ Explain the Judges cycle ☐ Explain how Boaz points to Jesus

Ambassadors (14–17) ☐ All Trailblazer items ☐ Name the 10 library sections and their book counts ☐ Teach one of this month's books (summary + motion + key verse) to a younger child ☐ Give a thoughtful answer to one Big Question ☐ Draw the family line from Rahab and Ruth to David to Jesus

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp Phase 3 in each child's Bible Passport with a **trumpet** stamp (or sticker) labeled: **"Phase 3 ✔ Into the Promised Land · Joshua · Judges · Ruth · 8 of 66."** Kids who finish can also color the first 3 spines of the History shelf on their Bible Bookshelf craft from Phase 1.

🏅 Phase badge: The Jericho Trumpet Badge

A brass-gold circle: a curved ram's-horn trumpet across the middle, a few tumbling bricks below it, and a small golden wheat sheaf (for Ruth) in the corner, with a thin red cord (for Rahab) wrapped around the edge. Banner: "BE STRONG & COURAGEOUS · JOSHUA 1:9." Make it from cardstock with ribbon, or as a sticker or patch for the sash.

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School Certificate of Completion: Phase 3, "Into the Promised Land"**
> This certifies that _____ has marched around Jericho with Joshua, met the judges, and gleaned with Ruth, learning **Joshua, Judges and Ruth**, the first three books of **HISTORY!** *"Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God will be with you wherever you go." Joshua 1:9* Books learned: **8 of 66** · Sections: **Law** ✔ · **History 3 of 12** · Teacher: _____ · Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page 🏠

Dear Parents and Caregivers,

This month we began the **History** section of the Bible with **Joshua, Judges and Ruth**. Your child learned how God brought His people into the Promised Land (the Jordan River crossing, the walls of Jericho, and brave Rahab with her scarlet cord), how Joshua challenged everyone to "choose... whom you will serve," how God sent judges like Deborah, Gideon and Samson whenever His people cried out, and how Ruth's loyal love and Boaz's kindness led to King David and, eventually, to Jesus, our Redeemer. Your child now knows **8 of the 66 books!**

📖 **Memory verse:** "Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God will be with you wherever you go." (Joshua 1:9, NIV) **Little Lambs:** "Be strong and courageous."

🎵 **Our song (sing all three parts in a row!):**

> *Twinkle tune:* Sixty-six books, one big story, / All about God and all His glory! ... *Ten Little Fingers tune:* Gen-e-sis, Ex-o-dus, Le-vit-i-cus, / Num-bers and Deu-ter-on-o-my, / God gave His Word to Mo-ses, / Five books of the LAW! *London Bridge tune:* Josh-u-a, Judg-es, then comes Ruth, / Then comes Ruth, then comes Ruth; / Josh-u-a, Judg-es, then comes Ruth: / His-to-ry starts here!

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions:**

1. What is something that makes you feel scared? How does Joshua 1:9 help?
2. What would "As for me and my household, we will serve the LORD" look like in our family this week?
3. Who has been a loyal friend to you, like Ruth was to Naomi?

👨‍👩‍👧 **Family activity: "Family Memorial Stones."** Joshua set up stones so families would remember what God had done. Find a few rocks together. On each one, write or draw something God has done for your family (a prayer answered, a new baby, a safe move, a friend). Put them in a bowl on your table. When someone asks, "What do these stones mean?" (Joshua 4:6), tell the story!

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search these channels on YouTube):

- **@SharefaithKids:** search "Jericho," "Gideon," "Ruth": `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jericho`
- **@BibleJourneyTV:** search "Joshua," "Ruth": `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Ruth`
- **@bibleproject:** "Overview: Joshua," "Overview: Judges," "Overview: Ruth": `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Joshua`

Next month: Phase 4, "Kings & Kingdoms." We'll learn 1 and 2 Samuel, 1 and 2 Kings, and 1 and 2 Chronicles: Samuel, Saul, David and Goliath, Solomon, Elijah, and more!

For more on the year, see `../00-start-here/program-overview.md` and `../00-start-here/books-of-the-bible-memory-system.md`.